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ABSTRACT

Human activity involves interconnections among civic, social, emotional, ethical, spiritual, and intellectual aspects. Recent advocacy for “whole person” education suggests that educators should attend to these multiple dimensions, but it does not provide an account of integration, of what “wholeness” means. We argue that those who facilitate development should encourage mutually reinforcing interconnections among various aspects of the individual, as well as interconnections among individual dispositions and social practices. Wholeness involves a jointly individual/social process of orchestrating others’ voices so as to develop normative stances in changing contexts that demand ongoing adjustment.

In a ninth-grade urban American classroom described by Wortham (2006), students were discussing an interesting question: is it possible to act virtuously while behaving unethically? More specifically, they explored whether is it possible to act courageously while doing something wrong. Tyisha gave an example to support her argument that it is.

Tyisha: Okay, I (hahaha) I had a friend and she was like, sneaking out with a boy, and she lied and said that she was going with her friends. (haha) and she told me, if her mother call, to tell her she was at the zoo with her friend Stacey. Now that took her courage to (haha) tell me

Student: (hahaha)

Tyisha: and it took (haha) courage for me to tell her mother that.

Tyisha lied to help a friend deceive her mother, and that was unethical. But this action involved risk, and it is reasonable to claim that Tyisha acted courageously. A coward would have refused to help her friend, one could argue, and perhaps Tyisha’s lie involved courageous determination to act in the face of potential harm. The teachers and students went on to have a productive discussion of this example, making arguments on both sides, and students learned something about virtue and courage.

Other things were also happening in this conversation, beyond these cognitive activities. In addition to being intellectually productive, Tyisha’s comment raised ethical and interactional issues. Because she described herself acting unethically, if the teachers characterized her behavior as virtuous they might risk praising such behavior. Tyisha adroitly slipped a description of unethical adolescent behavior into classroom discussion such that the teachers had to acknowledge her example as academically appropriate, even though many adults would condemn her action. This had become a pattern with Tyisha in this classroom before their January conversation about courage. She often introduced provocative content into classroom conversations. In this case she positioned herself as an adolescent who resisted adults’ ethical norms and who, as indicated by her laughter, enjoyed describing this within serious classroom conversation.

Tyisha's example was particularly skillful, but it illustrates a general fact. All intellectual activities, including classroom interactions, inevitably involve many aspects beyond their cognitive contents. In addition to the academic issues productively engaged in this conversation, several other things happened simultaneously. There were ethical aspects, including questions about Tyisha's character. There were social and civic aspects, including questions about the teachers' relationship with Tyisha and other students, about whether they would allow Tyisha to praise unethical behavior as "courageous," and about the norms that governed classroom interaction. There were emotional aspects, with Tyisha's pleasure at crafting an effective example, the other students' amusement, and the teachers' subsequent frustration. Education is not a purely cognitive activity, limited to subject matter, assessments, and the like. Whenever humans interact, even in activities that we often imagine as solely intellectual, we always find ethical, social, emotional, and other aspects. In fact, as we will elaborate below, cognitive processes are always inextricably interwoven with other aspects (Cantor et al., 2021; Fischer & Bidell, 2006; Wortham, 2006) – as demonstrated by how the ethical and relational challenges in this example depended in significant part on the intellectual content of Tyisha's contribution.

The cooccurrence and interdependence of multiple aspects of human functioning in intellectual activities raise questions about appropriate goals for education and for human development more broadly. Should education foster development in what are sometimes called "noncognitive domains?" Should the teachers have been trying to help Tyisha and her classmates develop civically, ethically, socially, emotionally, and in other ways – at the same time as they helped students learn the curriculum? Many have argued that education should indeed foster these other kinds of development. The last decade has seen an extraordinary resurgence of "whole person" educational movements that describe how educators should attend to and help young people progress in both intellectual and other aspects of human functioning (Wortham et al., 2020) – including "moral education," "character education," "social and emotional learning," "civic education," "flourishing," "well-being," and many others. Many movements claim to encourage the development of whole people, but it is unclear what "wholeness" means in this context. What should educators be developing, beyond young people's subject matter knowledge and academic skills? What would it mean to foster their development as *whole* human beings?

Divergent answers have been offered to this question, and it is unclear what exactly "wholeness" means as an educational and developmental goal. This article sketches an answer, bringing together insights inspired by cultural historical activity theory. We adopt a Vygotskian (1934/1986, 1997) approach, seeing the development of a coherent self as a process mediated by social tools and involving inter-functional connections across systems. We draw on Bakhtin's (1929/1984, 1981/1981) conceptualization of human development as the gradual "orchestration" of a distinctive "voice" out of the multiple social voices that speak through us. We incorporate insights from Holland (Holland et al., 1998; Holland & Lave, 2009) and Stetsenko (Stetsenko & Arievidt, 2004; Vianna & Stetsenko, 2011) about the inevitable interconnections between individual development and the social practices within which it takes place. We bring these perspectives together to argue that wholeness involves an essentially social process of orchestrating others' voices so as to develop distinctive, normative stances in changing contexts that demand ongoing adjustment. We present our argument in the three parts: exploring what it means to integrate multiple dimensions of human functioning; emphasizing the role of a normative vision to guide development; and understanding wholeness as an ongoing, unfinished process.

Integrating multiple dimensions

It has been known for millennia that educational interactions – like all human events – inevitably contain many types of activity. Humans never do only one type of thing at a time. We play politics, build relationships, experience and elicit emotions, make ethical judgments, reinforce or challenge social patterns, confront spiritual questions, and reason about our experience, for example, and we are almost always doing more than one of these things at once. Acknowledging this fact, many educational

and developmental theories, policies, and practices go beyond academic content to advocate development of both cognitive and other aspects. Advocates of civic education, for example, argue that schools should also help young people develop as citizens in a democratic society (Westheimer & Kahne, 2004) and develop civic dispositions, like the inclination to engage in deliberative discussion (Gutmann & Thompson, 2004). Advocates of “social and emotional learning” argue that schools should educate young people to recognize and manage their own and others’ emotions and that they should foster prosocial dispositions like empathy and cooperativeness (CASEL, n.d.). Advocates of character education argue for the development of intellectual, moral, civic, and performance virtues – like curiosity, humility, compassion, courage, civility, and perseverance (Arthur et al., 2016). Advocates of spiritual development argue that schools should help young people identify their purpose within a transcendent order (Plater, 2017; Taggart, 2001).

“Whole person education,” then, could be defined as practices that foster one or more additional aspects of human development beyond the subject matter. With respect to Tyisha and her teachers, for example, a commitment to whole person education in this sense might require attention to the social, emotional, and civic dimensions of the interaction introduced above. The two teachers in the classroom were explicitly committed to creating a particular kind of respectful, reflective conversation. They urged students to express their own opinions, as long as students offered arguments and treated others respectfully. Tyisha’s example was a civic and ethical challenge because it both deserved respect as an academic argument and also threatened to disrupt civic and ethical norms. After some productive conversation about Tyisha’s example, along with several moments of laughter and distraction, one of the two teachers explicitly instructed students about civic norms in the classroom. She did so because of a provocative comment in which Tyisha imagined more extreme unethical behavior and prepared to defend it as courageous.

Tyisha: If I go shoot you in the head

Teacher: shhhhhh

[students arguing]

Teacher: Ahh, if we can- if we can talk about courage as being something good, the virtue of courage, and go back to that definition, and I know you never bought into it, but the rest of us seem to be, using this as a definition, so therefore, we’d ask you to kind of go along with it.

In order to have productive conversation, sometimes individuals with divergent opinions need to put them aside so that the group can continue exploring issues of mutual concern. Tyisha had been consistently defending her claim that an immoral action could be courageous, but here – in order to reinforce social and ethical norms about civil behavior in the classroom – the teacher asked her to drop this topic.

In order to understand this example, we need a bit more background about the classroom. Tyisha and two-thirds of her classmates were African American students enrolled in a magnet program in a public urban high school. The students came from middle-class and working-class backgrounds. They had received above average but not outstanding test scores in a district-wide assessment, and their parents had applied to get them into this program – which was considered desirable but not elite. The program used great books pedagogy (Adler, 1982; Great Books Foundation, 1990) and this classroom had a curriculum of English and history texts that engaged questions about the relationship between the individual and society, the powerful and the powerless, and other classic issues, often formulated as essentially contestable questions. Tyisha herself was an intelligent, talkative student who participated regularly. Early in the year, teachers and fellow students considered her exemplary because of her regular, insightful contributions. As the year progressed, however, the teachers found her increasingly problematic and disruptive (Wortham, 2006).

In Tyisha’s comment about shooting someone in the head, we can see that she escalated her claims as the January classroom discussion went on. She appeared to enjoy the opportunity to discuss

unethical behavior in class, as shown in the sequence of increasingly colorful terms that she used to describe her lie: after initially using the verb “tell” to describe what she said to her friend’s mother (at line 283), she spiced this up, saying “I’m sitting here lying in another person mother face” (325–326); shortly thereafter she offered the even more colorful formulation, “her mother might have had trust in me and I come over and tell her this big bold-faced lie” (lines 339–341). Far from downplaying what she did, Tyisha embraced her unethical action. Her comment about shooting someone in the head culminated this escalation. While simultaneously engaging in academic discussion, Tyisha was entertaining herself and her peers by talking colorfully about her unethical behavior. In response, the teachers tried to bring Tyisha back toward a more normative academic conversation. They asked her to respect group norms about shared definitions and appropriate topics. In doing so, they were trying to foster civic, relational, and ethical development. They hoped to create dispositions – like concern for the group and respect for others – that would facilitate productive academic conversation and healthy relationships.

Integrating interdependent individual and social dimensions

All approaches to “whole person” education agree that educators should attend to civic, moral, emotional, spiritual, and/or other aspects of educational activities that extend beyond the academic. But treating these various aspects as discrete fails to recognize the inevitable connections among them. For example, Tyisha was making a rational argument, enjoying herself, displaying something about her character, and creating relationships with her peers – and all this happened simultaneously in just a few minutes of classroom conversation. These aspects were interdependent: if the example did not have salient academic and ethical implications, for instance, then it would not have been as much fun for Tyisha and her classmates; and her emotional engagement in this moment came in significant part from her desire to challenge her teachers and perform for her peers. Tyisha’s cognitive, civic, moral, and social actions and dispositions were all in play in this classroom, and any attempt to foster development has to grapple with their interconnections. Approaches that attend to multiple aspects as if they are isolated from one another cannot claim to be educating the whole person.

Our account of wholeness builds on both classic and recent work in developmental psychology, which has established the inevitable interdependence of cognitive, emotional, relational, ethical, and other aspects of human activity and human development (Cantor et al., 2021; Fischer & Bidell, 2006; Vygotsky, 1997). It is simply a fact that people have emotional reactions while doing academic work, that ethical challenges inevitably have cognitive and relational components, that spiritual journeys incorporate ways of thinking, emotions, and relationships with others, and so on. Humans and their environments are complex systems with heterogeneous, interdependent components. It can be useful to abstract out one aspect for analysis, but in fact these are inextricable (Overton, 2015).

One crucial fact about this interconnection is that the development of “whole people” extends beyond the individual. When advocates of whole person education urge the development of other aspects of human functioning in addition to the academic, they intend to create both individual dispositions and collective practices. The various dimensions of individual development are each partly constituted by sociocultural contexts (Rogoff, 2003; Vygotsky, 1934/1986). Dorothy Holland provides a useful perspective on this dialectic, describing how the development of individual persons is partly constituted by the enduring struggles and social practices within which that development happens (Holland et al., 1998; Holland & Lave, 2009). Instead of discrete, pre-formed individuals subsequently engaging with others in social activities, human life involves the emergence of coherent individuals as they participate in contentious, unfolding practice with each other. Anna Stetsenko describes how this process involves inevitable contribution and change in both the individual and the collective (Stetsenko & Arieviditch, 2004; Vianna & Stetsenko, 2011). We become ourselves through the joint emergence of inextricable selves and practices.

Tyisha’s classroom conversation illustrates the interconnections among individual development and emerging social practices. The teachers wanted to encourage Tyisha’s intellectual skills while at the

same time helping her to participate more productively in respectful academic conversation. They presupposed an ideal type of collective practice – one that involved the intellectual goal of understanding a text, as well as respect for others’ opinions and the systematic use of evidence – and they were trying to create classroom practice that approximated this ideal. They were concerned to develop students’ individual dispositions involving reflection, respect, evidence, and collaboration, as these took shape within the collective activity. Their developmental goals thus included transformation in systems that extend beyond the individual. The teachers tried to build a classroom community that followed norms of argument, evidence, and respect, and their goals for students’ civic and moral development involved individuals developing the dispositions required to participate in this collective practice. Wholeness means not just fostering the development of interconnected dispositions within individual students, but also the mutually reinforcing development of individual dispositions and social practices.

We can now clarify our terminology with respect to what we have been calling the multiple “aspects” of human functioning, distinguishing between activities, subsystems, dispositions, and practices. Human *activities* are particular events or types of events, and any activity involves cognitive, emotional, relational, ethical, and/or other aspects. These aspects can be abstracted out as *subsystems*, and they can be partly autonomous, but in any actual activity they are always interdependent. Individuals have *dispositions*, and these can be understood as connected to one or another subsystem, as in ethical dispositions, for example. Dispositions, however, always involve more than one subsystem – ethical dispositions inevitably include cognitive and emotional components, etc. As activity theorists have made clear, individual dispositions are also partly constituted by collective tools (Leont’ev, 1978; Vygotsky, 1997). Collectives engage in and sustain *practices*, which can also be understood as connected more closely to one subsystem, but they, too, are always engaged with more than one. Wholeness involves the joint development of dispositions and practices that connect subsystems in ways that support a normative ideal.

Integration as orchestration

Most approaches to “whole person” education acknowledge the inevitable interconnections across subsystems and dispositions in passing but nonetheless focus on particular aspects – enhancing intellectual, emotional, civic, ethical, or other discrete dimensions of development. Some, however, add another goal: educators should help young people not only to develop one or another aspect, but also to develop coherence across them (Higgins, 2017; Lerner & Callina, 2014). There are inevitably interconnections across aspects, but these interconnections can be more or less integrated and coherent. This is a normative argument that educators should help young people develop toward the integration of mutually reinforcing dispositions and practices across civic, ethical, emotional, social, and intellectual aspects. Higgins (2009), for example, argues that “it is not balance one seeks but wholeness,” in which various dimensions “can be re-integrated into the complex whole in which they belong” (p. 29). J. P. Miller (2007) and Pearl (2018) argue that wholeness requires many kinds of connections between “mind and body, between self and community, with the earth, and with our deeper selves as well as amongst disciplines” (Pearl, 2018, p. 37).

How could educators help students achieve coherence across intellectual, civic, moral, social, spiritual, and other aspects? Bakhtin’s theory of human development begins to provide an answer. He sees humans as always “on the boundary” between self and other. “A person has no internal sovereign territory, he is wholly and always on the boundary; looking inside himself, he looks *into the eyes of another* or *with the eyes of another*” (Bakhtin, 1929/1984, p. 287). Development does not involve a bounded self that subsequently establishes contact with bounded others. Instead, humans articulate themselves only through categories and stances borrowed from the social world. Because I am always in dialogue with others, using their voices in order to articulate my own stances, I am always on the boundary with them and I must articulate myself through their voices.

Bakhtin sees society as a complex, overlapping, tension-filled set of “voices” or social positions. These shifting voices speak with, against, past, and over each other. Each “voice” is a package of beliefs, emotions, social positions, and ethical stances. We understand “voice” to mean not merely a demographic position or a belief system, but instead a combination of mind, heart, identity, and spirit that is interconnected. In Tyisha’s classroom, for example, there were football players who sat in the back of the room and refused to participate except in one-word answers – enacting the voice of disengaged students whose interests lie elsewhere. There were devout Christian students who regularly cited scripture in response to the teachers’ questions. There were students deeply motivated by movements for racial justice. There were students who attended carefully to their clothing and appearance, with style a central value. There were students who wanted to be the teachers’ favorites, and there were others like Tyisha who regularly violated classroom norms. Each of these voices had a history, and most students enacted more than one of these social types. The classroom community contained these and other possible voices, each representing a different way of being – a characteristic set of thoughts, feelings, modes of relationship, and values drawn from the larger society.

Developing one’s own voice, a metaphor for developing a more coherent self, only occurs with maturity. Initially, young people speak with the voices of others coming through them, relatively uninflected. Children and adolescents, when speaking about politics, for example, often sound just like their parents or their teachers, with others’ voices coming out of their mouths. Over time, an individual becomes capable of expressing his or her unique stance by juxtaposing the voices of others. Bakhtin describes this as a developmental transition from “authoritative” to “internally persuasive” discourse.

One’s own discourse and one’s own voice, although born of another or dynamically stimulated by another, will sooner or later begin to liberate themselves from the authority of the other’s discourse. This process is made more complex by the fact that a variety of alien voices enter into the struggle for influence within an individual’s consciousness (just as they struggle with one another in surrounding social reality). (Bakhtin, 1981/1981, p. 348)

Whenever people try to “author” themselves, their words echo with the voices of others who are engaged in complex, overlapping struggles in the social world (Holland & Lave, 2009). Development involves the ability to “orchestrate” an independent voice out of this raw material. A more mature voice speaks through others, expressing its own stance by configuring them in a distinctive way, as a musical theme moves through and emerges from the various instruments in an orchestra.

Bakhtin articulates this developmental ideal with an analogy, describing a novelist who communicates by juxtaposing voices from the social world. The novelist does not speak directly in his or her own voice, but instead communicates a message by juxtaposing others’ voices.

The author builds a superstructure over these [voices] made up of his own intentions and accents, which then becomes dialogically linked with them. The author encases his own thought in the image of another’s language without doing violence to the freedom of that language or to its own distinctive uniqueness. (Bakhtin, 1981/1981, p. 409)

Talented novelists evoke real voices from the social world and juxtapose them in ways that capture the voices’ authenticity, but they also compel these voices to serve the overarching intention of the author. He calls this process the “orchestration” of social voices, using the metaphor of an orchestral theme that moves across different voices in a symphony. Novelists communicate by invoking recognizable cognitive/emotional/social/evaluative packages and juxtaposing these in distinctive ways. This, we argue, is a useful conceptualization of the developmental process through which people develop toward wholeness: the gradual articulation of a coherent voice, one that is established by incorporating other voices from the social world.

In Tyisha’s case, her example about lying created tension between the intellectual development that her argument facilitated and the ethical and civic development that the teachers also wanted to encourage. The teachers tried to eliminate this tension and align these developmental pathways by arguing that, in fact, the courageous reaction in Tyisha’s situation would have been to reject her friend’s request and refuse to lie. In this way they continued to engage the intellectual topic, while also

asking Tyisha to consider alternative courses of action and alternative ethical stances. They were trying to retain her positive emotional energy without encouraging the development of an oppositional identity. They were encouraging her to reflect on her ethical choices while incorporating her as a member of the classroom community. By asking students to participate in respectful, evidence-based classroom conversation – in which participants discuss then agree on shared definitions, for example, – the teachers gave Tyisha and other students opportunities to develop individuals’ civic, relational, and ethical dispositions while also strengthening the collective practice of respectful intellectual conversation. By fostering the dispositions and practices required for such conversation, the teachers were developing students’ abilities to incorporate civic, relational, emotional, ethical, and intellectual subsystems.

Despite the teachers’ efforts, during January and February Tyisha nonetheless consistently pushed against classroom norms and distracted teachers and students with topics like shooting people in the head. Sometimes the teachers explicitly labeled her as “disruptive,” and they periodically asked her to be quiet and withdraw from the conversation. In the spring, however, as illustrated in the following excerpt, Tyisha’s position changed.

Tyisha: All this stuff is probably phony.

Teacher: All of this stuff is phony? You’ve been in a class now for the last seven months where you’ve been receiving phony information?

Tyisha: And nobody cannot tell me, prove it to me that this is true. So I just listen and talk, just like I believe it.

Teacher: Well, you know, I think that’s a good point. I think that you should question. What would be the evidence that this might be true?

In this conversation, instead of criticizing Tyisha for refusing to believe information from the text, the teacher praised her for demanding evidence. The teacher continued:

I appreciate your skepticism. I think, I think it’s right. I think that you need to sometimes say, where is this information coming from? But I’d also like you to recognize that you’re not the first person to have those questions and that there are people who have devoted their lives to authenticating, to saying is this really real or did somebody make it up.

Here the teacher reinforced some of the civic and ethical standards that are central to substantive academic discussion. Participants must be appropriately skeptical and demand evidence, and the teacher praised Tyisha by saying that she exemplified this stance. The teacher encouraged Tyisha to adopt the practices and develop the dispositions that are cultivated within an intellectual community that values reasoned skepticism. If Tyisha were to do so, it would move her toward greater coherence across parts of her self. She already had social and emotional dispositions that led her to engagement with others in the classroom. She also had dispositions that led her to question authority. The teacher was saying that these dispositions would allow her to fit well into a particular role in a more ideal intellectual community – if she would act as a reasoned skeptic and help the group interrogate arguments and evidence. Tyisha could bring together emotional, civic, social, and intellectual dispositions in a way that would strengthen the classroom academic community and sustain key practices in intellectual conversation. If she were to adopt the role of a reasoned dissenter, this would allow an integration of various dispositions in a way that facilitated productive classroom practice. By orchestrating voices of engagement, skepticism, and respect, she could move toward coherence both within herself and with others in a more ideal collective practice.

In Vygotskian terminology, we might say that this move toward coherence would result from developmental advances made possible by links across functional systems. Vygotsky (1997) describes how humans develop by bringing together formerly disparate systems into combinations that allow new types of action. The classic example involves emergent connections between thinking and speech

in the child. But he also describes subsystems that involve motivation, emotion, will, and other domains beyond the cognitive. A movement toward wholeness can involve deepening integration among such subsystems, making possible higher functioning. The teachers were hoping that the emerging practice of reasoned academic conversation in the classroom could provide a context in which Tyisha might connect emotional, ethical, intellectual, and relational subsystems by enacting a more coherent voice for herself as a reasoned skeptic.

Orchestration toward a normative purpose

Interconnections among cognitive, emotional, relational, ethical, and other aspects are inevitable in human activities. We have argued that particular kinds of interconnection – more integrated, coherent ones – should be a central educational goal. But what are “more integrated, coherent” dispositions and practices? In order to answer this question, we must first acknowledge that coherence by itself does not suffice as a developmental goal. Coherence must be a “means to a greater end” (Gruenewald, 2002). According to Cottingham (2010), “the psychological wholeness that is sought is not consistency for its own sake, but the coherence and clarity of vision that is prepared to acknowledge an *objective system of values* which we did not create, and which we cannot alter by our own preferences, however committed they may be” (p. 12). Coherence itself does not suffice as a goal for developing whole human beings. Educators must guide students toward finding some larger purpose that this coherence serves. We cannot solve the philosophical problem of identifying good, bad, and ideal forms of coherence and purpose in this short article. From an educational and developmental point of view, however, we argue that coherence can be a project for individuals.

MacIntyre (1984) provides an account of narrative coherence that is useful here. “The unity of a human life is the unity of a narrative quest” (p. 219), in which human beings build their own life stories in alignment with some larger goal. Such a story imagines how our ethical choices, social relationships, intellectual positions, spiritual yearnings, and other aspects work together toward a worthwhile end. MacIntyre argues that any individual’s story depends on social context, because it is meaningful only as it connects with others’ stories and the values and practices that are embodied in collective life. Coherence depends on a “thick” vision of a good human life, a collective understanding of what human flourishing entails that can only be sustained within a robust community (MacIntyre, 1988; McLaughlin, 1996). This account fits with the arguments by Stetsenko and Arievidtch (2004) and Holland and Lave (2009) about the inevitable interconnections between emerging individual dispositions and social practices that together can help constitute a more coherent self. Dispositions and practices co-evolve, sometimes in ways that facilitate integration across dimensions because the dispositions and practices work together toward some larger purpose.

From MacIntyre’s perspective, educators should help young people construct coherent lives by encouraging reflection and action that incorporate ethics, relationship, intellect, spirituality, and other aspects – and connect them in a developing life story. In Tyisha’s case, for instance, the teachers took advantage of her autobiographical example to engage with questions about her past ethical choices, how she understood these choices, and the kinds of values she wanted to live by. By asking whether she might have refused her friend’s request and thereby behaved more virtuously, they were hoping that Tyisha might reimagine and perhaps redirect her life story. By trying to incorporate her energy and insight into the practice of respectful academic conversation, they attempted to create a story for her across the academic year that built connections among her emotions, her academic insights, and her relationships with others. They hoped that she might become a reasoned dissenter and play this important role in the practice of rigorous, respectful academic conversation.

In order to create more coherent selves, Culham and Bai (2011) argue that individuals and collectives must develop a robust sense of purpose that encompasses various dimensions. This sense of purpose emerges from a “thick” vision of the good life. Damon defines purpose as “a stable and

generalized intention to accomplish something that is at once meaningful to the self and of consequence to the world beyond the self” (Damon et al., 2003, p. 121). In order to overcome tensions, achieve coherence, and facilitate ethical action, various dimensions of human functioning must be directed toward some larger goal in the social, natural, or transcendent realm. Discernment of and movement toward a higher purpose can help people become more whole human beings.

Many have made this point in terms of “spiritual” development (Gruenewald, 2002; R. Miller, 1990). “Spirituality” here does not necessarily mean affiliation with an organized religion. Both religious and more secular belief systems can support a sense of being called to participate in a larger moral order. Spiritual development in this sense means, first, that educators must ask young people to discern their commitments to a more ideal state of the world and their roles in that world. People might be drawn toward an ecological vision of a flourishing natural world, a political vision of social justice and dialogue, a relational vision of care for the other, a religious vision of a transcendent order, or some other vision of how the world is meant to be. Any such vision must move beyond merely instrumental ends. Second, it means asking young people to bring themselves and others closer to that ideal. This is not indoctrination. Educators in a heterogeneous society should not prescribe one vision of the moral order over other possibilities. But a commitment to developing purpose requires young people to ask questions about what the world needs them to do – while giving them latitude to discern their own vision of a moral order. Educators who engage students with purpose in this sense can help them work toward productive integration across aspects, guided by a thick normative vision, and this will facilitate the development of whole human beings.

Tyisha began to engage with questions about purpose in the spring when the curriculum incorporated aspects of her own racialized history and connected her to a “thick” collective vision of the kind MacIntyre describes. In the segment below, the class was discussing a fictional character (from Steinbeck’s *The Pearl*) who confronts a choice between accepting what he is given by the dominant power structure or fighting for a more just outcome. The teacher offered Jim Crow America as an analogy.

Teacher: I, excuse me, I’m a southern state and uh, I’ll give you an education Jasmine. I’ll give you an education in that building over there, with all these kids crammed in, with textbooks that are fifty years old or you can take a chance and you can stand up to the power structure, and maybe even pull your kids out of school and boycott schools for a while and maybe not get any education at all for a while because you want a real education and not this Jim Crow education.

...

Jasmine: But in the long run, wait a minute, in the long run you might not even get nothing, so you just gonna sit there.

Tyisha: I’d rather go try, than just sit there and say this is about sitting down. I think I could have got more than that. I’m not gonna sit there no longer, I’m gonna go out and search for some money. I’m not gonna be like that.

In the spring semester, teachers had opened up a possible identity for Tyisha as a reasoned skeptic or legitimate dissenter, channeling her consistent skepticism into a productive role that contributed to the civic order of the classroom. The topic of Jim Crow America allowed Tyisha to embrace this role with respect to a social reality that she and other Black students experienced. Instead of taking pleasure in disrupting classroom conversation and entertaining her peers, Tyisha took this opportunity to join with her Black classmates and imagine a more just educational system in America. She said that she would fight in the ongoing struggle for racial justice in America, not just hypothetically, by analogy with the character in the story, but also in actuality. The teachers’ two interventions – recruiting Tyisha as a legitimate dissenter instead of a disruptive outcast and using an example that drew on the African

American students' own experiences with racial injustice – gave Tyisha an opportunity to integrate several aspects of herself. Socially and civically, she was able to join with her peers and take a leadership role, in a way that also allowed her to participate in academically productive conversation. She was emotionally motivated by this topic, and it allowed her to participate in a purposeful, collective project tied to the “thick” purpose of the American civil rights movement. This brought together civic, relational, emotional, ethical, spiritual, and intellectual aspects such that they were, for the moment, working together. By incorporating a larger purpose – the struggle for a more just society in the face of anti-Black racism – Tyisha was able to bring together her developing social position as a classroom leader, her developing emotional engagement both in the academic conversation and with the larger civil rights movement, her developing intellectual understanding of curricular themes about power and justice, and her developing ethical dispositions with respect both to classroom participation and social change.

The introduction of a topic that connected to a “thick” purpose was crucial to facilitating this coherence across dimensions that began to emerge for Tyisha. Educating “whole students” should not only facilitate the development of multiple aspects, but it should also work toward coherence across these aspects. By connecting students to a purpose, and by giving them a chance to tell stories that connect themselves and their communities to a larger vision, educators can create a space for young people to integrate dispositions and practices by connecting cognitive, emotional, relational, ethical, spiritual, and other aspects.

Wholeness as an unfinished process

Tyisha's teachers hoped to foster the development of dispositions and practices such that students would enthusiastically participate in intellectually robust classroom conversation that followed norms of respect and evidence. They also selected curriculum that engaged students with ethical, civic, and spiritual questions about their responsibilities toward others and the larger world. Their conversation about Jim Crow approached this ideal, and in that moment civic, social, emotional, ethical, spiritual, and intellectual subsystems came together for Tyisha and some of the other students. But one conversation does not suffice to build enduring dispositions and practices, and subsequent classroom conversations were not consistently like this one. Students became distracted, other curricular materials were less engaging, tensions and contradictions emerged, and external factors interfered.

Wholeness must be an ongoing project. The process of articulating one's own voice – which Bakhtin calls a “gradual formation” (1935/1981, p. 407) – never ends. As Holland et al. (1998) say, “identities – if they are alive, if they are being lived – are unfinished and in process” (p. vii). Development is always “jagged” (Cantor et al., 2021). The social reality through which we articulate ourselves involves contestation, contradiction, and change. Dialogue among voices in heterogeneous, changing social reality is ongoing. The dialogic process of articulating a self, which takes place by juxtaposing those shifting voices, is also ongoing. For this reason Stetsenko and Arievitch (2004) argue that the self must be “constantly re-enacted and constructed by individuals anew in the ever-shifting balances of life” (p. 493). Bakhtin calls this process “unfinalized.” “Finalization” would mean solidification into a permanent structure, which Bakhtin associates with totalitarianism. Humans are “not finalized by anything (not even death)” (Bakhtin, 1929/1984, p. 284), because the live interplay of voices continues. Persons are “composites of many, often contradictory, self-understandings and identities, whose loci are often not confined to the body but ‘spread over the material and social environment,’ and few of which are completely durable” (Holland et al., 1998, p. 8).

We have suggested that people can move toward more coherent selves through the orchestration of others' voices, through the creation of a life story guided by a thick collective vision, and through the integration of cross-functional subsystems. But wholeness cannot be accomplished once and for all because life continues and we always face new challenges which

demand adjustments. Coherence is also provisional because all human systems contain tensions and contradictions. The psychosocial systems within which education and human development occur do not reach equilibrium (Kauffman, 1995; Prigogine & Stengers, 1984; Vygotsky, 1934/1986, 1997). Leont'ev (1978) called these “activity systems” – composed of individuals, social tools like technology and language, and social organization like the division of labor. We cannot make sense of individual development without understanding the activity systems within which it takes place. Activity systems inevitably contain multiple points of view, traditions, and interests, and the synergy or tensions among these are essential to the character and development of the system. Following Hegel (1807/1977) and Marx (1867/1990), activity theory emphasizes historical change and the fact that contradictions are inevitable in all systems. Some positions in the educational system, for example, – like business executives who want well-trained workers and parents who want their children to get jobs – expect schooling to prepare young people to take an established role in society, as if society is a stable organism that individuals slot into. Others, however – like social reformers, many students, and some teachers – want schooling to prepare young people to change society instead of reproducing it. This tension between stability and change can create conflict between groups and struggle over practices like standardized testing and ability tracking. From the perspective of activity theory, such a “contradiction” can generate productive change (Engeström, 1987).

Because contradictions are inevitable, the search for coherence in whole person education cannot be a search for stable unity. The inevitable tension in activity systems is not a bug to be eliminated, but a feature that propels development and historical change. The creation of a coherent self is an ongoing negotiation between individual actions, relationships within a system, and the resources available to each person (Black et al., 2010; Calabrese Barton et al., 2013). This process always involves dialectical tension, which creates conflict but can also productively advance the process of working toward an unfinalized but nonetheless more coherent identity. As Black et al. summarize, drawing on Stetsenko and Arievidt (2004), “the ‘self’ is not a static or fixed personal attribute which we can ‘have’ but a process, constructed and performed through engagement in activity and always in development” (Black et al., 2010, p. 58).

Tyisha and her teachers thus could not aim for a stable set of dispositions and practices which would cause her to react in a consistent way once she reached a “mature” or “educated” state. We have already described one persistent tension illustrated by Tyisha’s example: the tendency for students to be emotionally engaged by and personally identified with activities that diverge from rational argument and respectful classroom conversation. Educators would like students to be engaged by and identified with activities that align more closely with dominant intellectual, civic, and ethical standards. The teachers’ opened a space for Tyisha to position herself as a reasoned skeptic, and this provisionally resolved the tension. This allowed Tyisha to direct her energy toward contributions that fit the collective practice of rational group conversation. But the contradiction between student engagement and curricular content in general would require a more extensive modification of habitual practices in classrooms and more enduring organizational changes of the sort articulated over a century ago by Dewey (1916). Even such changes, however, would be provisional. We must create systems of dispositions and practices that are stable enough to persist but flexible enough to adapt as new tensions and contradictions arise.

Conclusions

Tyisha began the academic year relatively fragmented. She was interested in some of the subject matter, and she liked to argue. But she also liked to entertain her friends and provoke the teachers. Sometimes she enacted the voice of a successful student as that role was imagined in the idealized academic conversations that the teachers had in mind. Sometimes she enacted

the voice of a younger child, easily distracted and knocked off course. Sometimes she enacted the voice of an entertainer, playing to other students as an audience. Sometimes she enacted the voice of a rebellious adolescent, deliberately undermining the teachers. It took many months, until late in the academic year, before the teachers were able to help her work toward greater coherence. Instead of asking her to give up her desire to confront others and resist authority, they provided a space in which she could weave this disposition into her new identity as a reasoned skeptic. Instead of asking her to give up the pleasure of shocking and entertaining others, they allowed her to accomplish this in a role that also contributed to academic conversation. When they asked her to be a legitimate dissenter on the topic of Jim Crow and systemic racism, she seized the opportunity to bond with other African American students and embrace a thick collective purpose that provided direction. This gave Tyisha an opportunity to integrate various aspects and become more whole – although, like all of us, she did not reach a stable final state.

This provisional coherence required a sense of purpose, faith in an ideal: “Not faith (in the sense of a specific faith in orthodoxy, in progress, in man, in revolution, etc.) but a *sense of faith*, that is, an integral attitude (by means of the whole person) toward a higher and ultimate value” (Bakhtin, 1929/1984, p. 294). A sense of purpose, a vision of a more ideal world – what Stetsenko and Arievidtch (2004) call a “gravitation pole” – is crucial to developing coherence. In Tyisha’s case, this involved a connection to movements for racial justice, which also bonded her with fellow students in a larger project that included cognitive, emotional, relational, ethical, and spiritual aspects. We never reach the ideal state envisioned in our sense of purpose, but faith in such a higher value can facilitate movement toward it. This means that educators can help students work toward coherence by engaging them in discernment about the collective projects they are called to participate in.

“Orchestration” of others’ “voices” is a powerful metaphor for understanding the ongoing development of whole human beings. “Voices” are packages of ideas/feelings/identities/values that include individual dispositions and collective practices characteristic of particular social locations. Young people try on these packages, and through repeated participation in practices they can develop dispositions that help them fit emerging social positions. “Wholeness” is not a preexisting state that young people are socialized into. It is, instead, an ongoing accomplishment in which they develop dispositions that integrate multiple aspects and allow them to create their own stances within the changing social world. We have argued that educators can facilitate the development of more coherent dispositions and practices by encouraging young people to discern a higher purpose and their role in it. Following Bakhtin, we see whole person education as a process of orchestrating others’ voices so as to develop our own distinctive, normative stances by playing a productive role in evolving practices.

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